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THE REDESIGN PLAYBOOK



*A step-by-step system for rebuilding a website that is slow, dated,
or no longer sounds like your business — done yourself.*

BY MK PARRISH · \$45

TABLE OF CONTENTS

-
- 01 Your Website Is Either Working Or Leaking
 - 02 Chapter 1: The Audit
 - 03 Chapter 2: Message Before Design
 - 04 Chapter 3: The Page Architecture
 - 05 Chapter 4: Mobile-First And Fast
 - 06 Chapter 5: Design That Converts
 - 07 Chapter 6: The Rebuild And Launch Checklist
 - 08 When To Do It Yourself, And When To Call
-

YOUR WEBSITE IS EITHER WORKING OR LEAKING

Most websites do not fail loudly.

They fail quietly. A visitor lands, waits a beat too long for the page to load, squints at text built for a desktop that shrank onto their phone, cannot tell in five seconds what you do or why it matters, and leaves. You never see them. There is no error message for a customer who simply decided you were not worth the effort.

This playbook is the self-guided version of the redesign work I do with clients. It is for the founder, consultant, or small team with a site that has not been touched in a few years — slow, hard to use on mobile, or just no longer representing the business you have become. You do not need to be a designer or a developer. You need a system, a sharp eye, and the willingness to make decisions in the right order.

That order is the whole game. Most redesigns fail because people start with the paint — a new template, a trendy font, a color they saw somewhere — before they have decided what the site is *for*. We are going to work from the inside out: message first, structure second, design third, speed and polish last. Do it in this order and the site almost designs itself.

CHAPTER 1: THE AUDIT

You cannot fix what you have not measured. Before you touch a single pixel, score your current site honestly across four dimensions. Rate each from 1 to 5.

Performance. Open your site on your phone, on cellular data, not wifi. Count the seconds until you can read and tap something. Under three seconds is good. Over five is bleeding. Run it through any free speed tool and note the score. Slow sites do not just annoy people; they get buried, because search engines rank speed.

Clarity. Show your homepage to someone who does not know your business for five seconds, then hide it. Ask them: what does this company do, and who is it for? If they cannot answer, your message is the problem, not your traffic.

Mobile experience. More than half of your visitors are on a phone. Scroll your whole site on mobile. Is the text readable without zooming? Are the buttons big enough to tap with a thumb? Does anything overflow the edge of the screen? Every friction point here is a customer lost.

Conversion path. Pick your most important page. Can a visitor tell what to do next in one glance? Is there one obvious action, or five competing ones? A page with five equal buttons has no button at all.

Write your four scores down. This is your baseline, and at the end you will beat it. Anything scoring a 3 or below is a priority. Do not try to fix everything at once — fix the leaks first.

CHAPTER 2: MESSAGE BEFORE DESIGN

Here is the mistake that costs the most: treating a website like a decoration instead of an argument.

A good site makes an argument. It says, in order: here is who this is for, here is the problem, here is what changes, here is why me, here is what to do next. Design is just the way you make that argument legible and beautiful. If the argument is muddy, no template will save it.

So before you open any design tool, write four sentences in plain language:

- **Who it is for.** Name the person. "Growth-stage B2B founders," not "everyone."
- **What changes.** The outcome they get, not the features you ship.
- **Why you.** The specific reason you are the right choice — the edge only you have.
- **What to do next.** The single action you want most visitors to take.

These four sentences become the spine of your homepage. If you get them right, the rest of the site is just expansion. If you skip them, you will spend weeks arranging furniture in a house with no foundation.

Read your current homepage headline out loud. Does it say what you **do**, or does it say something clever that sounds like every other site in your industry? Clever is not the goal. Clear is the goal. Clear, then interesting, then never at the expense of clear.

CHAPTER 3: THE PAGE ARCHITECTURE

Most small business sites need fewer pages than they have, each doing its job well. Here is the core set and the single job of each.

Home. The whole argument, compressed. Headline that names the outcome, a subhead that adds proof or specificity, a primary button, then sections that expand each part of the argument: the problem, what you offer, proof, and a closing call to action. The homepage is not a table of contents. It is a pitch.

Services / Offer. What you do, framed around what the buyer gets. For each offer: who it is for, what is included, what it costs (or how to find out), and the next step. Vagueness here reads as evasiveness. Name your prices or name the range.

About. Not your autobiography — a trust page. Why you do this, who you have done it for, and the values that make working with you feel safe. People buy from people. Give them the person.

Contact / Book. One clear way to start. A form, a calendar link, an email. Remove every extra choice. The job of this page is to make saying yes effortless.

Anything beyond these earns its place or gets cut. A tight four-page site that converts beats a sprawling twelve-page site nobody finishes.

CHAPTER 4: MOBILE-FIRST AND FAST

Two non-negotiables in a modern rebuild. Get these wrong and nothing else matters.

Design for the phone first. Do not design a beautiful desktop layout and hope it survives the shrink. Start with the narrow screen. If your message, your proof, and your button work in a single thumb-scrollable column, they will work everywhere. Big text. Generous spacing. Buttons you can hit without aiming. Nothing that requires a pinch or a zoom.

Make it fast. Speed is a feature customers feel before they can name it. The three biggest culprits are almost always the same: oversized images, too many plugins or scripts, and heavy fonts. Compress every image before you upload it — most sites ship photos ten times larger than they need. Cut plugins you do not use. Limit yourself to one or two font families. A fast site feels expensive. A slow site feels neglected, no matter how pretty it is.

Test on a real phone, on real data, one more time. The gap between "fine on my laptop" and "fine for a customer standing in line" is where trust is won or lost.

CHAPTER 5: DESIGN THAT CONVERTS

Now, and only now, the visual layer. Three principles do most of the work.

Hierarchy. Every screen should have one thing that is clearly the most important. The biggest, boldest element is what the eye lands on first, so make sure it is the thing that matters — usually the headline or the button. If everything shouts, nothing is heard.

Proof where fear lives. People hesitate right before they commit. Put your evidence there — testimonials, logos, numbers, before-and-afters — next to the buttons and the prices, not buried on a separate page. Proof is most persuasive at the exact moment of doubt.

One clear action per screen. Decide the single next step you want, and make it the obvious move. Repeat that same call to action down the page. A confused visitor does nothing, and doing nothing is the most common thing a website visitor does.

Restraint is the sophistication here. A calm layout with one strong voice reads as confidence. A busy layout with five competing messages reads as anxiety. Cut until it feels almost too simple, then ship it.

CHAPTER 6: THE REBUILD AND LAUNCH CHECKLIST

You have the argument, the architecture, and the design principles. Here is the sequence to build and ship without missing the things that quietly break trust.

- Write every page's copy first, in a plain document, before you lay it out.
- Build mobile layout first, then expand to desktop.
- Compress all images; replace anything blurry or dated.
- Set one primary call to action per page and make it visually dominant.
- Add proof next to every place you ask for money or commitment.
- Check every link, every form, and every button — actually submit the form.
- Read every page aloud on your phone. Fix anything you stumble over.
- Add the basics of findability: real page titles, descriptions, and legible headings.
- Set up a simple way to measure visits and actions, so you can see what works.
- Launch, then watch real behavior for two weeks and fix the top friction point.

A redesign is not done when it looks good. It is done when a stranger can land, understand, trust, and act — on a phone, in a hurry, without your help.

WHEN TO DO IT YOURSELF, AND WHEN TO CALL

This playbook can take a capable owner most of the way. Do it yourself when you have the time, the taste, and a site whose problems are clarity and structure — things words and decisions fix.

Call in help when the problem is deeper than a weekend: when the site is technically broken, when the stakes are high enough that every week of a weak site is real lost revenue, or when you simply know your time is worth more spent on the business than on the build. That is the work I do — a full audit, redesign, and rebuild, hands-on from start to finish. If that is the season you are in, the door is open at mkparrish.com/redesign.

Either way, the principle holds. Your website is not a brochure. It is your hardest-working salesperson. Build it to earn its keep.

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